



Protecting Your Heart During Breast Cancer Treatment

A patient handout based on peer-reviewed research | Bring this to your next appointment

WHY THIS MATTERS

Some breast cancer treatments — anthracycline chemotherapy (like doxorubicin), HER2-targeted drugs (like trastuzumab/Herceptin), and radiation near the chest — can strain the heart. Caught early, heart strain can usually be managed or reversed. Heart disease, not cancer, is the leading cause of death among breast cancer survivors.

4 in 10

women saw a heart doctor within 90 days of starting treatment — 6 in 10 did not

148 days

the typical wait for a first cardiologist visit — 5 months

22–34%

lower odds of an early visit for women in food deserts or doctor-shortage areas

Source: study of 2,637 women aged 66+ who received these treatments (Huang et al., *Clinical Breast Cancer*, 2026)

CALL YOUR CARE TEAM IF YOU NOTICE

- ♥ New shortness of breath
- ♥ Swelling in legs or ankles
- ♥ Unusual or worsening fatigue
- ♥ A racing or fluttering heartbeat
- ♥ Chest pressure or discomfort
- ♥ Sudden weight gain (fluid)

Don't wait for your next scheduled visit — these symptoms deserve a call the same day.

FIVE QUESTIONS TO ASK YOUR CANCER TEAM

- ☐ **“Could my treatment affect my heart?”**
Ask if your plan includes anthracyclines, HER2-targeted drugs, or chest radiation.
- ☐ **“Should I see a cardiologist or cardio-oncology clinic — and when?”**
An early referral is reasonable to request, especially with blood pressure, diabetes, or heart history.
- ☐ **“What heart symptoms should make me call you?”**
Get a clear list and the best phone number to use.
- ☐ **“Can any of this be done closer to home, or by video?”**
Telehealth, local labs, or bundling heart checks with oncology visits can cut travel.
- ☐ **“Is there help with transportation or food?”**
Oncology social workers can connect you with ride programs and food assistance — ask.

Based on: Huang P-L, Mysore MM, Barr B, Onukwughu E. *Clinical Breast Cancer* 2026;26(2):191–203. Open access: doi.org/10.1016/j.clbc.2025.08.020

This handout is general education, not medical advice. Decisions about your care should always be made with your own clinicians.

More: lynnhuang-peilin.github.io/website/neighborhood-heart-care.html